

The four causes and the nature of being

Because of his practical disposition and interest in natural and physical sciences, Aristotle did not restrict himself to moral philosophy as much as Socrates and Plato had done. As well as examining the way in which we acquire knowledge of the world around us, he questioned what made things the way they are – the nature of being. He believed that we cannot have any knowledge of something until we understand its ‘why’: how it came to be, and in particular the explanation for change or movement of an object or event. Aristotle suggested four distinct categories of explanation, which he called ‘causes’, of how a thing has come about:

- material cause (the material the thing is composed of).
- formal cause (the structure of the thing, or its blueprint).
- efficient cause (more akin to our modern understanding of cause, meaning the outside agency or event that brings it about).
- final cause (what a thing has come about for – its purpose or aim, but in a very wide sense).

